

Under the Knife

If you thought cosmetic surgeries were meant for adults, here's a reality check. Kids are no longer afraid of the surgeon's knife and are ready to go any length to look groomed.

PECTORAL IMPLANTS

Implants made of silicon are inserted into the male chest to make it look puffed up and muscular. Boys in the age group of 14-18 prefer this.

SURGERY COSTS: Rs 1-1.25 lakh

SIDE EFFECTS: Silicon can react with the body or the implant can rotate, as the male chest lacks the tissue required to support silicon implant. It can cause atrophy of muscle and contracture.

RHINOPLASTY

Cartilage or bone is inserted into the nose to make it straight, sharp, soft or remove hump on the nose. Silicon implants or cartilage from other body parts is used for this surgery.

SURGERY COSTS: Rs 35,000-60,000

SIDE EFFECTS: If done in the teens, when skeletal growth is incomplete,

cartilage or bone can warp and cause deformity as the child grows. If silicon is used, in about 10 per cent cases, it can lead to exclusion of silicon.

BREAST IMPLANTS

Silicon implants are inserted in the breast tissue to increase size.

SURGERY COSTS: Rs 1.25 lakh

SIDE EFFECTS: Doctors claim they are completely safe in adult women. If done in early teens, when the breast formation is not complete, there isn't enough tissue to insert the silicon. Breasts can develop till the early 20s.

LIPOSUCTION

Excess body fat is extracted in a liquefied form. Generally done in specific problem areas of the body especially if the patient is dysmorphic and the fat is

very difficult to get rid of.

SURGERY COSTS: Rs 30,000 for 3-4 litres of fat

SIDE EFFECTS: If the safe limits (6 to 8 per cent of body weight) of fat removal is exceeded, it can cause blood loss, fat embolism which means fat can get into the circulation in the blood or kidneys.

SKIN LIGHTENING

Chemical peels are used to scrub off the degenerative skin and stimulate regenerative skin.

SURGERY COSTS: Rs 6,200 for three sessions plus maintenance.

SIDE EFFECTS: If new, regenerative skin is not properly protected, it can react with make-up or sunlight or chlorine from the swimming pool. In children, the skin is not mature enough to take the treatment.

Apart from missing out on a healthy adolescence, the obsession with looking good could also have far reaching emotional and psychological repercussions. Today, the mindest has changed and so have aspirations. Children no longer aspire to be doctors or engineers, this generation is interested in modelling or acting. Explains Dhody, "Now it is a part of the cultural ethos to look good and children are swept away by this huge wave of peer pressure."

Parents are often blackmailed into giving in to irrational and even potentially harmful demands. Says Dr Taneja, "Most times, parents consent without understanding the full implications. Kids think that liposuction is an alternative to diet and exercise for weight loss, which it is not." It can result in complications like fat going into kidneys and the blood stream.

"My kids are developing a look good and feel good outlook. The cost of beauty treatment is worth it."

**KAJAL ARORA,
PARENT, CHANDIGARH**

To put it simply, what the brat brigade wants, the brat brigade gets. And parents, unfortunately, are either helpless bystanders or catalysts of this change. But the question that the society at large needs to ask is that even if parents are willing accomplices, should the medical fraternity not raise the red flag at this trend. While cosmetic surgeries on young and even minor pa-

tients are legal and ethical, Dr Vijay Panjabi, president of Indian Medical Association, Maharashtra state, says: "In a democracy, it is the patient's choice to look good and highlight their features. If we have consent of parents in case of minors and the doctor is confident of the surgery, it is absolutely ethical to operate."

Justifying the desire of children and their parents to look good, medical experts believe that if the doctor is transparent, then it's perfectly ethical. However, the rate at which cosmetic surgery shops are mushrooming and the stupendous rise in the number of minor patients surely deserves some introspection, that is if we don't want to put an expiry date on childhood.

**with Jhilmil Motihar, Nandini Vaish,
Ramesh Vinayak, Nirmala Ravindran,
Akhila Krishnamurthy and Swagata Sen**